Higher or Lower?

America in 10 numbers



How to play

- I show you a number, then something new
- You guess: is the new one higher or lower?
- Stand up for higher, stay seated for lower
- Keep your own score, out of 10

Round 1: higher or lower?

Eurovision 2026

TV viewers worldwide (Vienna)

131

million

vs.

Super Bowl 2026

TV viewers in the USA

?

Eurovision: everyone reached over three live shows in 35 countries (EBU via AFP, June 2026). Super Bowl: average US audience (Nielsen, 2026).

Round 1: higher or lower?

Eurovision 2026

TV viewers worldwide (Vienna)

131

million

vs.

Super Bowl 2026

TV viewers in the USA

125.6

million

LOWER

Eurovision: everyone reached over three live shows in 35 countries (EBU via AFP, June 2026). Super Bowl: average US audience (Nielsen, 2026).

The Super Bowl

- The NFL final, on a Sunday in February
- 2026: Seattle 29, New England 13
- The most-watched TV broadcast in the USA, every year
- Halftime show: Bad Bunny
- Americans ate about 1.48 billion chicken wings that day
- In Austria it starts at 00:30 on Monday morning



Super Bowl XLIII, 2009. US Air Force, public domain

Sources: Nielsen; National Chicken Council (2026).

Round 2: higher or lower?

Super Bowl 2026

TV viewers in the USA

125.6

million

vs.

Thanksgiving

Turkeys eaten in one day

?

Source: National Turkey Federation (estimate for Thanksgiving 2025).

Round 2: higher or lower?

Super Bowl 2026

TV viewers in the USA

125.6

million

vs.

Thanksgiving

Turkeys eaten in one day

≈ 30

million

LOWER

Source: National Turkey Federation (estimate for Thanksgiving 2025).

Thanksgiving

- Fourth Thursday in November: this year, November 26
- 1621: Pilgrims and Wampanoag share a harvest meal
- A national holiday since 1863 (Abraham Lincoln)
- Turkey, stuffing, cranberry sauce, pumpkin pie
- The President "pardons" a turkey every year
- The next day is Black Friday



Photo: Ms Jones, CC BY 2.0

Round 3: higher or lower?

Thanksgiving

Turkeys eaten in one day

≈ 30 million

vs.

Fourth of July

Hot dogs eaten in one day

?

Source: National Hot Dog and Sausage Council (industry estimate).

Round 3: higher or lower?

Thanksgiving

Turkeys eaten in one day

≈ 30

million

vs.

Fourth of July

Hot dogs eaten in one day

150

million

HIGHER

Source: National Hot Dog and Sausage Council (industry estimate).

The Fourth of July

- Independence Day: the Declaration of Independence, July 4, 1776
- 2026 was the USA's 250th birthday
- Barbecues, parades, fireworks
- Nathan's Hot Dog Eating Contest, Coney Island, New York
- 2026 winner: Joey Chestnut, 66 hot dogs in 10 minutes
- His record is 76



Nathan's contest, 2025. Photo: SOCJ, CC BY 4.0

Source: AP (July 4, 2026).

Round 4: higher or lower?

Fourth of July

Hot dogs eaten in one day

150

million

vs.

Bruno Mars

Monthly listeners on Spotify

?

Source: Spotify via kworb.net (November 10, 2026).

Round 4: higher or lower?

Fourth of July

Hot dogs eaten in one day

150

million

vs.

Bruno Mars

Monthly listeners on Spotify

≈ 125

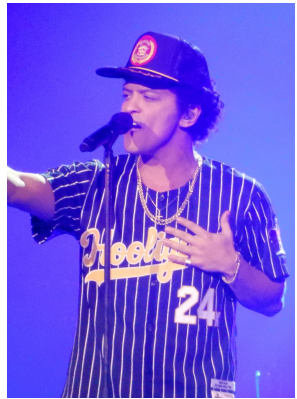
million

LOWER

Source: Spotify via kworb.net (November 10, 2026).

Bruno Mars

- Born 1985 in Honolulu, Hawaii
- The most-listened-to artist on Spotify
- First artist ever to pass 150 million monthly listeners (2025)
- Played the Super Bowl halftime show in 2014
- “Uptown Funk”, “Die With a Smile” (with Lady Gaga), “APT.” (with Rosé)
- 2026: new album *The Romantic* and a stadium tour



2017. Photo: slgckgc, CC BY 4.0

Sources: Guinness World Records (2025); Atlantic Records (2026).

Round 5: higher or lower?

Bruno Mars

Monthly listeners on Spotify

$\approx$ **125**

million

vs.

US national parks

Visits in one year

?

Source: National Park Service (2025 visits).

Round 5: higher or lower?

Bruno Mars

Monthly listeners on Spotify

$\approx$ **125**

million

vs.

US national parks

Visits in one year

323

million

HIGHER

Source: National Park Service (2025 visits).

National parks

- Yellowstone (1872) was the world's first national park
- Today: 63 national parks, and more than 400 protected sites
- 323 million visits in 2025: almost one for every American
- Most visited national park: Great Smoky Mountains (11.5 million)
- The classic American holiday: the road trip
- Austria has 6 national parks



Grand Canyon. Photo: Chensiyuan, CC BY-SA 4.0

Source: National Park Service (2026).

Round 6: higher or lower?

US national parks

Visits in one year

323

million

vs.

Ford F-Series pickups

Sold in the USA in one year

?

Source: Ford (2025 sales).

Round 6: higher or lower?

US national parks

Visits in one year

323

million

vs.

Ford F-Series pickups

Sold in the USA in one year

828,832

trucks

LOWER

Source: Ford (2025 sales).

Car culture

- The best-selling vehicle in the USA is a pickup truck
- The Ford F-Series has been #1 for 44 years in a row
- An F-150 is almost 6 metres long
- Most Americans can drive alone at 16
- Outside a few big cities, there is no life without a car
- Drive-through restaurants, banks, pharmacies, even weddings



2024 Ford F-150. Photo: Deathpallie325, CC BY 4.0

Source: Ford (2026).

Round 7: higher or lower?

Ford F-Series pickups

Sold in the USA in one year

828,832

trucks

vs.

High school football

Boys playing on a school team

?

Source: NFHS High School Athletics Participation Survey (2025–26).

Round 7: higher or lower?

Ford F-Series pickups

Sold in the USA in one year

828,832

trucks

vs.

High school football

Boys playing on a school team

1,043,716

players

HIGHER

Source: NFHS High School Athletics Participation Survey (2025–26).

School sports

- In the USA, sport happens at school, not in clubs
- Over 8.4 million high school students play on a school team
- Friday night football: the whole town comes to watch
- Cheerleaders, marching bands, homecoming
- Universities too: Michigan's stadium holds 107,601 people
- Good players can get a university scholarship



Friday night football in Celina, Texas. Photo: Heidi Knapp, CC BY-SA 4.0

Source: NFHS (2026).

Round 8: higher or lower?

High school football

Boys playing on a school team

1,043,716

players

vs.

McDonald's

Restaurants in the USA

?

Source: McDonald's (September 2026).

Round 8: higher or lower?

High school football

Boys playing on a school team

1,043,716

players

vs.

McDonald's

Restaurants in the USA

≈ 13,800

restaurants

LOWER

Source: McDonald's (September 2026).

Fast food

- McDonald's started in California in 1940
- Ray Kroc turned it into a franchise from 1955
- About 13,800 in the USA; about 200 in Austria
- About one in three American adults eats fast food on a given day
- Free refills, huge portions, drive-throughs
- Other giants: Subway, Starbucks, Chick-fil-A, Taco Bell

Source: CDC, National Center for Health Statistics (2021–23 data).

Round 9: higher or lower?

McDonald's

Restaurants in the USA

$\approx$ **13,800**

restaurants

vs.

One year at Harvard

Tuition, room and food

?

Source: Harvard University (cost of attendance, 2026–27).

Round 9: higher or lower?

McDonald's

Restaurants in the USA

$\approx$ **13,800**

restaurants

vs.

One year at Harvard

Tuition, room and food

$91,634

dollars

HIGHER

Source: Harvard University (cost of attendance, 2026–27).

Paying for college

- $91,634 is the “sticker price”: tuition, a room and food
- Many students pay much less, thanks to financial aid
- Public universities are cheaper, but still not free
- About 43 million Americans have student loans
- Average debt: about $40,000
- In Austria: €26.20 per semester



Harvard Yard. Photo: Marco Almbauer, public domain

Sources: Federal Student Aid; USAFacts (2026); ÖH (2026/27).

Round 10: higher or lower?

One year at Harvard

Tuition, room and food

$91,634

dollars

vs.

Super Bowl advert

Price of 30 seconds

?

Sources: Financial Times; Wall Street Journal (2026).

Round 10: higher or lower?

One year at Harvard

Tuition, room and food

$91,634

dollars

vs.

Super Bowl advert

Price of 30 seconds

≈ $8

million

HIGHER

Sources: Financial Times; Wall Street Journal (2026).

The adverts are the show

- $8 million for 30 seconds: about $267,000 per second
- Many Americans watch the Super Bowl *for* the adverts
- Companies release them online days before the game
- Celebrities, jokes, talking animals
- The same price as 87 years at Harvard

Final score

10	Honorary American
7–9	Ready for a road trip
4–6	Needs more hot dogs
0–3	At least you know Eurovision

Think

Which number surprised you most?

What would the Austrian version of this game look like?